Carlotta's Confession

By Donald Hall

INTRODUCTION

Our Father, Who art in heaven, hallowed be Thy name; Thy kingdom come; Thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread; and forgive us our trespasses as we forgive those who trespass against us; and lead us not into temptation but deliver us from evil. Amen.

O my God, I am heartily sorry for having offended you and I detest all my sins, because I dread the loss of heaven and the pains of hell. But most of all because I have offended you, my God, who are all good and deserving of all my love. I firmly resolve with the help of your grace, to confess my sins, to do penance and to amend my life. Amen.

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"My grandfather's name was Augusto,
        *'ow-**goose**-toe'* the way he said it.
He sailed from Sicily, Palermo
        to Newark, when he was fifteen
and not quite five feet tall.
        With American food, with the remarkable

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effluents of New Haven, Connecticut,
        and the gun factory,
he stretched out to five-foot-one.
        At thirteen I was two inches taller
than my grandfather - Carlottina
        the Giantess - and I daydreamed
of becoming a nun. Augusto caressed us,
        teased us, screamed at us,
and praised us - as long as we went
        to Mass; I adored my grandfather
and when he died, named my first child Augustus.
        Gus was eight for the divorce;
Mary, who is Maria now, was three
        and contented. My boyfriends
teased Gus and brought him presents;
        on weekends it was Harry's girls. I was
miserable and called it adventure.
        Devils the nuns had described
vividly for us jabbed forked tails
        into me, and for every jab I took
my revenge by destroying something else:
        I had a late abortion;

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I married again - for six weeks.
From the third grade on, Gus spent more hours
in the principal's office after school
than he did on the playground.
I got him into Country Day at ten:
They expelled him for fighting.
He was twelve the first time
the police called me; at fifteen, larceny
and a year in reform school. Then
no more school and no jobs that lasted:
Gus never finished anything
except a joint or a pint of wine.
He never went back to a shrink
for a second appointment. Of course
he made resolutions; there was a sweetness
to him that broke my heart,
and my heart always broke
with his resolutions. When he was twenty
he resolved to kill himself:
Naturally we argued about it;
sometimes I won the arguments,
but a week later - I made pasta

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every Sunday night - he'd return
with more reasons. Sometimes with a new
job or girl he'd drop the subject;
then there'd be another disaster
and he'd disappear for a week.
On a wet Sunday a month ago –
after he lost a good job
and signed up for welfare again, and moved
in again with a girlfriend
who cheated on him - he telephoned me
to say goodbye; he had said goodbye
many times before but this time
he called his own bluff -
and he failed again. The shoplifted .22
caliber target pistol left him
in Intensive Care on his back
with his eyes open and his left
cheek twitching every nine seconds.
They had hooked him up to a machine
but he lay staring beyond
my fury and my love forever.
For two weeks I sat beside him

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all night while machines breathed
for him, rasping and hissing like metal cats.
In my head I kept arguing with him:
Now the argument ran to
pulling or not pulling the plug. What a quarrel!
Once as I drove home
from the hospital at midnight
for a little induced sleep before
a court session in the morning,
my mind ran a movie, like those scenes
in pantomime that they show
behind titles: I watched myself tiptoe
into Gus's hospital room
in a gray light; then I glanced over
my shoulder to see that no one followed;
then I suffocated him.
The next morning the old judge delivered
his order; after supper,
with Maria holding me, I kissed Gus
a last time. The head nurse turned
the switches off one by one.
By one. Very, very slowly his heartbeats,

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visible on the green monitor,
blipped farther apart. One breath
a minute. Two minutes. Then there were none.
Next afternoon we buried
him in the non-denominational
(meaning Protestant) graveyard.
For three days I felt gay; then the guilt:
Repeatedly I went over
his life from the beginning, finding
that my errors ruined his life,
fault breeding fault breeding fault:
selfishness, lust, cruelty, greed, malice,
laziness, pride. I married myself
to failure, now I was failure's
widow. I tried going to church, say
what you like, where I hadn't gone since
my first divorce: My tongue grieved
for my grandfather's wine and wafer.
First, I needed to make my confession,
my litany of error,
and I told the young priest how
I had broken each of the commandments

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except the one that forbids us to kill.

The moment I heard myself

speak I laughed aloud - but I didn't

laugh with amusement: Carlotta

the mother who aborted one child

and daydreamed strangling another.

For penance he said - a Hail Mary.

Hail Mary, full of grace. Our Lord is with thee. Blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the fruit of thy womb, Jesus. Holy Mary, Mother of God, pray for us sinners, now and at the hour of our death. Amen.

'Your sins are forgiven,' he said."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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Prayers appear in order as follows:

1. ***The Lord's Prayer***
2. ***The Act of Contrition Prayer***
3. ***Hail Mary Prayer***

SOURCE: ***https://www.xavier.edu/jesuitresource/online-resources/prayer-index/catholic-prayers#:~:text=us%20from%20evil.-,Hail%20Mary%2C%20Full%20of%20Grace%2C%20The%20Lord%20is%20with%20thee,and%20to%20the%20Holy%20Spirit.***

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